

openhouse

art & design · ages 8-12

the artiverse book

the art we make – and why



a teacher's companion to every artwork · 21 units

why these artworks – in this order

Every artwork teaches a specific **skill** through a technique a child can genuinely do – running **easiest** → **hardest**, each with a **medium symbol**. This book carries **both** the studio's exemplar pieces **and** real works by working artists (marked **new**), so children see the full range.

 oil pastel
  watercolour/tempera
  acrylic
  mixed media
  pencil
 chalk pastel

1		tomato composition oil pastels	S&F	C&P	●○○○○○	
2		flowers watercolour	C&P	L&T	●●○○○○	
3		abstract waves acrylic	L&T	C&P	●●○○○○	
4		donut new acrylic	S&F	C&P	●●○○○○	
5		colour grid study new watercolour	C&P	B&C	●●○○○○	
6		orange study watercolour	C&P	B&C	L&T	●●●○○○
7		paul klee city watercolour	B&C	S&F	I&C	●●●○○○
8		warhol-style cats watercolour	C&P	B&C	●●●○○○	
9		scenery oil pastels	B&C	C&P	●●●○○○	
10		blue lotus new watercolour	C&P	L&T	●●●○○○	
11		pear · glazing new watercolour	C&P	S&F	●●●○○○	
12		klee portrait new mixed media	B&C	S&F	I&C	●●●○○○
13		pomegranate study acrylic	C&P	S&F	●●●○○○	
14		jellyfish new watercolour	C&P	L&T	●●●○○○	
15		octopus new watercolour	S&F	C&P	●●●○○○	
16		self-portrait new watercolour	C&P	I&C	B&C	●●●○○○

why these artworks – continued

17		van gogh landscape new oil pastels	C&P	L&T	● ● ● ● ●
18		reach the sky mixed media	B&C	S&F	● ● ● ● ●
19		aurora landscape chalk pastels	C&P	B&C	● ● ● ● ●
20		3d cube new pencil	S&F	C&P	● ● ● ● ●
21		dragonfly at night new acrylic on black paper	C&P	B&C	● ● ● ● ●

skills across the book: line & texture · shape & form · colour & painting · balance & composition · imagination & collaboration – revisited at rising difficulty (the spiral).

a note on the artworks: pieces marked **new** are reference works by independent artists, shown for classroom teaching inspiration only, with thanks – individual artist credits are being added. All other pieces are openhouse studio exemplars. Please don't reproduce or share the reference images outside class.

tomato composition

oil pastels

the objective

Fill deliberate shapes with strong, controlled colour – no blending – to make a bold, graphic still life.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Bold shapes, controlled filling – draw clean shapes, then press firmly to fill each with flat, even colour, keeping edges crisp.

1. Draw the tomatoes as clean, simple shapes.
2. Fill each firmly with even colour.
3. Keep edges crisp – no blending between shapes.

why it's good for children

A confident start for the older band – controlled filling teaches precision and patience, and a bold graphic result builds the confidence to commit to strong choices. It sets the discipline the harder units rely on.

how to encourage them

Put a real tomato on the table. *"Fill right to the edge – take your time."* Praise clean, even colour.

materials

oil pastels · cartridge paper · a real tomato

where it sits in the spiral

the book's disciplined starting point – controlled colour returns in every painting unit.



what we make – a bold still life

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a single tomato · a bowl of tomatoes · a market stall

flowers

watercolour

the objective

Work with clean, transparent washes and place colours in deliberate relationships.

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Light washes, colour placement – load a watery brush, lay clean transparent washes, and let colours meet softly.

1. Mix watery, transparent colour.
2. Lay a clean wash for each petal – don't overwork it.
3. Place a second colour beside it and let them meet.

why it's good for children

Watercolour rewards **restraint** – children learn that leaving the white of the paper and not overworking a wash is a skill in itself. Placing colours in relationship builds real colour judgement.

how to encourage them

"Less is more – let the water do the work." Discourage overworking; praise clean, fresh washes.

materials

watercolours · a round brush · watercolour paper

where it sits in the spiral

introduces the transparency and restraint the layering units build on.



what we make – a loose watercolour flower study

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a single bloom · a bunch of flowers · flowers in a jar

abstract waves

acrylic

the objective

Use hands to make gestural, moving marks that feel alive with energy and rhythm.

skills it builds

line & texture

colour & painting

the technique

Finger painting, movement – apply acrylic with the fingers and hands, sweeping and dragging to make marks full of movement.

1. Load fingers with acrylic.
2. Sweep and drag to make flowing wave marks.
3. Layer a second colour to build energy.

why it's good for children

Working with the hands frees children from wanting it perfect and puts the focus on **movement and rhythm** – a genuine artistic quality. It's a physical, joyful counterpoint to the controlled units.

how to encourage them

"Let your whole arm move." Encourage energy over neatness.

materials

acrylic paint · thick paper

where it sits in the spiral

a loose, expressive unit that balances the precision work around it.



what we make – a gestural wave painting

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: ocean waves · a storm · a calm sea

donut 🍩

acrylic

the objective

Lay clean, flat areas of colour with crisp edges – no blending.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Flat fill, colour blocking – fill each area with even, solid colour up to a clean edge, one at a time.

1. Sketch the donut shapes.
2. Fill each area with flat, even colour.
3. Add sprinkles and highlights last.

why it's good for children

Colour blocking builds control and a **designer's eye** – clean edges and confident flat colour are the foundation of graphic art, and the playful subject keeps a technical skill fun.

how to encourage them

"Even colour, clean edge – take your time."

materials

acrylic · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

the disciplined starting point – precision that the tonal units build on.



what we make – a bold, appetising donut

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a sprinkled donut · a box of donuts · a bitten donut

colour grid study

watercolour

the objective

Mix and place colours deliberately in a grid, exploring how they relate side by side.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Colour theory – mix a clean colour for each square and place warm and cool families thoughtfully.

1. Draw a simple grid.
2. Mix and fill each square with one clean colour.
3. Arrange warm and cool so the grid feels balanced.

why it's good for children

A grid makes **colour itself** the subject – children practise mixing and see how colours change beside each other, the foundation of every painting that follows.

how to encourage them

"Which colours feel warm? which feel cool? put them where they belong."

materials

watercolours · a palette · paper

where it sits in the spiral

pure colour practice underpinning the painting units.



what we make – a grid of mixed colours

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a warm-cool grid · a rainbow grid · a tone grid

orange study

watercolour

the objective

Combine three techniques – wash, stencil and collage – in one piece to build surface and depth.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

line & texture

the technique

Wash + stencil + collage layering – lay a wash, add stencilled shapes, then collage torn paper to build layers.

1. Lay a watercolour wash as the base.
2. Add stencilled or masked shapes on top.
3. Collage torn paper for the final layer of depth.

why it's good for children

Combining techniques asks children to **plan and sequence** – a real step up in thinking. Layering teaches how surface and depth are built, not found.

how to encourage them

Plan the order together – “*which layer first?*” Encourage patience between layers.

materials

watercolours · stencils / masking · torn paper · glue

where it sits in the spiral

the first multi-technique unit; the planning here supports the layered paintings ahead.



what we make – a layered citrus study

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a cut orange · oranges and leaves · a citrus arrangement

paul klee city

watercolour

the objective

Combine flat painted shapes to build a whole composed scene (Paul Klee's method).

skills it builds

balance & composition

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Paint + collage composition – divide the page into shapes, paint each thoughtfully, and let them build a city.

1. Divide the page into many shapes.
2. Paint each with considered colour.
3. Let the shapes become buildings and streets.

why it's good for children

A real **composition** challenge – children think about the whole page and how colour and shape balance across it. Studying Klee links their work to art history and shows abstraction can be joyful.

how to encourage them

Show a Klee painting. *"Which shape is a tower? a road?"* Praise balanced, interesting arrangements.

materials

watercolours · paper

where it sits in the spiral

whole-page composition; the balance thinking here deepens through the book.



what we make – an imaginary city of shapes

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a city of shapes · a castle town · a world of colour

warhol-style cats 💧

watercolour

the objective

Explore one subject across a full range of light-to-dark values within a single colour family.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Monochrome tonal work – pick one colour and build the whole image using its lightest to darkest tones.

1. Choose one colour family.
2. Mix it from very light to very dark.
3. Build the cat using tone alone.

why it's good for children

Working in one colour forces children to **see tone** – the light-to-dark structure beneath all painting – without the distraction of colour choices. It's a foundational skill that transforms later work.

how to encourage them

"How many shades of one colour can you find?" Praise a full tonal range.

materials

watercolours · paper

where it sits in the spiral

introduces tone – the key to the 3D and layering units that follow.



Sam



Sam Sam



Sam



Sam



Sam



Sam

what we make – a monochrome tonal study

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a cat in one colour · a repeated pet · a pop-art portrait

scenery

oil pastels

the objective

Build a landscape in layers, using tone to create distance and atmosphere.

skills it builds

balance & composition

colour & painting

the technique

Layering, tonal build-up – lay the sky and far layers first, then build nearer layers on top.

1. Lay the sky and farthest layer first.
2. Build nearer hills and fields on top.
3. Add foreground detail last.

why it's good for children

Landscape teaches how **tone and layering create depth** – far things paler, near things stronger. Children learn to think about a whole scene and its atmosphere.

how to encourage them

"What's far away? what's close?" Praise a sense of depth.

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

composition + tone together in a scene; prepares the spatial and atmosphere units.



what we make – a layered landscape

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a sunset · mountains · a field at dusk

blue lotus

watercolour

the objective

Build a flower from clean transparent washes, petal by petal, with restraint.

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Light washes, layering – lay a clean wash for each petal, letting the white paper show, and deepen tone where petals overlap.

1. Mix watery, transparent blue.
2. Paint each petal as one clean wash.
3. Deepen the tone where petals meet.

why it's good for children

Watercolour rewards **restraint** – leaving the white of the paper and not overworking a wash is a skill in itself. Building petal by petal teaches patience and control.

how to encourage them

"Less is more – let the water do the work."

materials

watercolours · a round brush · watercolour paper

where it sits in the spiral

clean layered washes – the ground for glazing next.



what we make – a blue lotus in clean washes

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a lotus · a water lily · a single bloom

pear · glazing

watercolour

the objective

Layer transparent washes (glazing) to build a rounded, glowing form.

skills it builds

colour & painting

shape & form

the technique

Glazing – let each wash dry, then add another transparent layer on top to deepen colour and build roundness.

1. Lay a pale first wash for the whole pear.
2. When dry, glaze a deeper layer on the shadow side.
3. Keep glazing until the pear looks round and glowing.

why it's good for children

Glazing is a genuinely advanced idea – children learn that **transparent layers** build form and light without muddying the colour. It grows patience and an eye for tone.

how to encourage them

"Wait for it to dry, then add the next glaze." Discourage rushing.

materials

watercolours · a brush · watercolour paper · a real pear

where it sits in the spiral

layering becomes form – tone deepens through the book.

wash of this pear



what we make – a glowing pear

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a single pear · a pair of pears · a pear and its shadow

klee portrait

mixed media

the objective

Build a portrait from geometric shapes and warm colour (Paul Klee's 'Senecio').

skills it builds

balance & composition

shape & form

imagination & collaboration

the technique

Geometric portrait – divide a face into circles, triangles and rectangles, then fill with warm, balanced colour.

1. Draw a round face and divide it into shapes.
2. Colour each shape with warm, balanced colour.
3. Keep the eyes and mouth simple and geometric.

why it's good for children

Building a face from **shapes, not likeness** makes portraits achievable and joyful, and studying Klee links the child's work to art history. Balancing colour across the face is real composition.

how to encourage them

Show Klee's *Senecio*. *"Which shape is the nose? the eyes?"*

materials

oil pastel / paint · paper

where it sits in the spiral

composition meets art history; balance deepens here.



what we make – a face built from shapes

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a face of shapes · a portrait in warm colour · a Senecio of my own

pomegranate study 🎨

acrylic

the objective

Build a painting in layers from dark to light, each layer adding volume and detail.

skills it builds

colour & painting

shape & form

the technique

Layering, tonal build-up – start dark, then add progressively lighter layers to build form and highlights.

1. Block in the darkest tones first.
2. Add mid-tones to build the round form.
3. Finish with the brightest highlights.

why it's good for children

Building **dark-to-light** is how real painters create volume – a genuinely advanced idea that makes flat shapes look solid and lit. Patience across layers grows focus and craftsmanship.

how to encourage them

"Dark first, light last – build it up slowly." Discourage rushing to detail.

materials

acrylic paint · a brush · paper · a real pomegranate

where it sits in the spiral

applies the tone learned in the Warhol unit to build real 3D form.



what we make – a rich, rounded fruit study

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: a cut pomegranate · a bowl of fruit · a single glowing fruit

jellyfish

watercolour

the objective

Use wet-into-wet washes to make a soft, translucent, moving form.

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Wet-into-wet – wet the paper, drop in colour and let it bloom softly; pull long trailing tentacles with a fine brush.

1. Wet the bell area and drop in soft colour.
2. Let the colours bloom and blend on their own.
3. Pull long, wavy tentacles while damp.

why it's good for children

Wet-into-wet is watercolour at its most magical and least controllable – children learn to **let go** and work with the water, capturing movement and translucency.

how to encourage them

"Let the water carry the colour – don't fight it."

materials

watercolours · a soft brush · watercolour paper

where it sits in the spiral

the loosest, most atmospheric watercolour – movement and light together.



what we make – a drifting jellyfish

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a single jellyfish · a bloom of jellyfish · a deep-sea drift

octopus

watercolour

the objective

Capture a soft, moving creature with flowing washes and curling line.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Form & movement – build the body with a wash, then pull curling arms with a loaded brush, varying the pressure.

1. Paint the soft, rounded body.
2. Pull eight curling arms with a flowing brush.
3. Add suckers and pattern once dry.

why it's good for children

An octopus asks for both **soft form and lively line** – children observe a moving creature and translate it into confident, curling marks.

how to encourage them

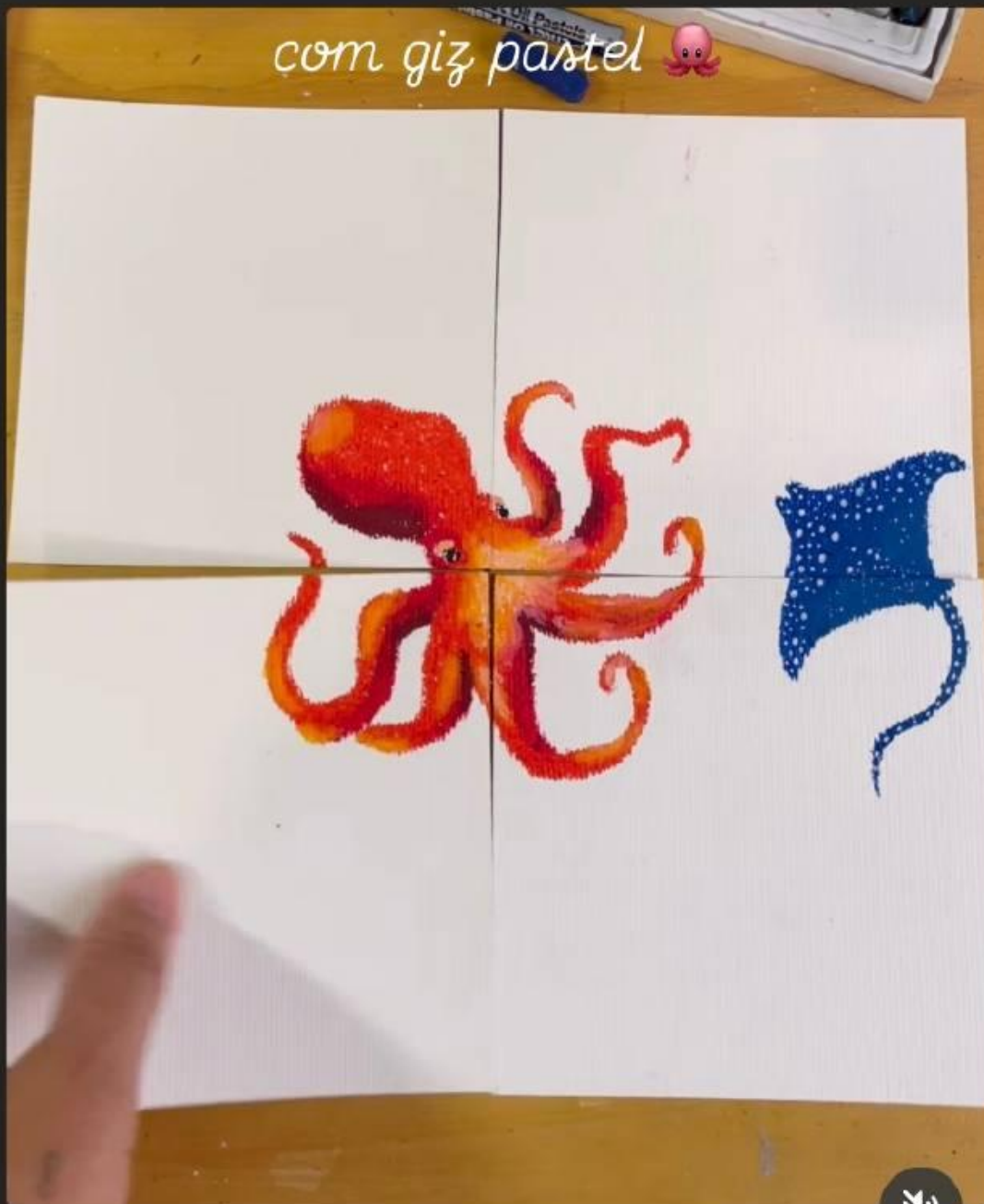
Show a real octopus clip. *"Make the arms curl and move."*

materials

watercolours · a round brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

washes plus expressive line – a step toward the mark-driven units.



what we make – a curling octopus

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: an octopus · a squid · a sea creature in motion

self-portrait

watercolour

the objective

Paint a self-portrait using bold, non-literal colour to express identity and mood.

skills it builds

colour & painting

imagination & collaboration

balance & composition

the technique

Expressive colour – paint the face in confident, unexpected colours that capture a feeling rather than exact likeness.

1. Sketch the face large and simple.
2. Paint it in bold, expressive colour.
3. Add strong marks for hair and features.

why it's good for children

A self-portrait is deeply **personal**, and using bold colour frees children from needing an exact likeness – they express identity and mood, growing confidence and self-expression.

how to encourage them

"What colour is your mood today? paint yourself in it." Celebrate boldness.

materials

watercolours · a brush · paper

where it sits in the spiral

colour becomes expression and identity.



what we make – an expressive self-portrait

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: me in bold colour · my face, my mood · a fearless portrait

van gogh landscape

oil pastels

the objective

Use bold directional marks to fill a landscape with movement and mood (Van Gogh).

skills it builds

colour & painting

line & texture

the technique

Expressive marks – layer oil pastel in swirling, directional strokes so the whole scene seems to move.

1. Lay directional strokes for sky, field and trees.
2. Layer colours in the same flowing direction.
3. Blend a little to make the marks move.

why it's good for children

Van Gogh's method shows children that **marks carry emotion** – the direction of a stroke creates movement and feeling. It links technique to expression, a sophisticated idea.

how to encourage them

Show a Van Gogh landscape. *"Make the whole picture move."*

materials

oil pastels · paper

where it sits in the spiral

mark-making becomes expressive across a whole scene.



what we make – a landscape full of movement

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: cypresses · a wheatfield · a swirling sky

reach the sky

mixed media

the objective

Combine materials to build a scene with clear depth and scale across the whole page.

skills it builds

balance & composition

shape & form

the technique

Spatial composition – use size, overlap and placement to make some things feel near and others far.

1. Plan what's near and what's far.
2. Make near things bigger, far things smaller.
3. Overlap and place them to build depth.

why it's good for children

Deliberately creating **depth and scale** is advanced composition – children learn that where and how big they place things controls the whole feeling of a picture. Combining materials adds real craft.

how to encourage them

"How do we make this feel far away?" Praise a convincing sense of space.

materials

mixed media · paper · found materials

where it sits in the spiral

the fullest composition unit – depth and scale, near the book's peak.



what we make – a scene with real depth

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: reaching a kite · a tall tower · looking up at the sky

aurora landscape

chalk pastels

the objective

Build luminous, atmospheric colour through pressure and blending across large areas.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Layering, blending, atmosphere – lay broad areas of chalk pastel and blend with fingers to build soft, glowing colour.

1. Lay broad bands of colour across the sky.
2. Blend with fingers to soften the edges.
3. Layer brighter colour where the light glows.

why it's good for children

Chalk pastel blends into soft, **luminous atmosphere** unlike any other medium – children learn to create mood and light across a whole surface, the culmination of the book's colour and composition work. A glowing result feels magical.

how to encourage them

"Blend it soft – make the sky glow." Encourage big, atmospheric colour.

materials

chalk pastels · dark paper

where it sits in the spiral

the book's peak – colour, tone and atmosphere together on a large scale.



what we make – a glowing aurora sky

openhouse studio exemplar

topic options: northern lights · a glowing night · a magical sky

3d cube

pencil

the objective

Understand how one light source creates volume through graduated tone.

skills it builds

shape & form

colour & painting

the technique

Light, shadow, 3D form – pick a light direction, then shade each face lighter or darker so the shape looks solid.

1. Draw the cube's three visible faces.
2. Choose where the light comes from.
3. Shade each face lighter or darker to match.

why it's good for children

A genuine leap into **how we see form** – a flat shape becomes a solid object through tone alone. It's the foundation of realistic drawing and a real 'aha'.

how to encourage them

Shine a light on a real box. *"Which face is lightest? darkest?"*

materials

graphite pencil · paper · a box + a lamp

where it sits in the spiral

tone becomes form – the structure beneath all representational art.



what we make – a solid 3d form

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a cube · stacked blocks · a row of 3D shapes

dragonfly at night 🦋

acrylic on black paper

the objective

Work on a dark ground, building from dark to light to make things glow.

skills it builds

colour & painting

balance & composition

the technique

Painting with light – on black paper, add light and bright colours so the creature appears to glow against the dark.

1. Start on black paper – plan where the light is.
2. Build glows softly with white and bright colour.
3. Add the brightest highlights last, sparingly.

why it's good for children

Reversing the usual approach – **light on dark** – is the hardest and most magical idea in the book. It asks children to think about **light itself**, plan an atmosphere, and hold back. A glowing result feels like magic they made.

how to encourage them

"The dark makes the light glow – use it sparingly."

materials

acrylic · black paper · a fine brush

where it sits in the spiral

the book's peak – colour, composition and atmosphere on the hardest ground.



what we make – a glowing night creature

artwork shown as inspiration, with thanks to the artist

► reference by an independent artist – full artist credit to follow

topic options: a dragonfly · fireflies in a jar · a glowing pond